

L23 — Stack Operations: PUSH & POP; Parenthesis Matching

Unit: 2 | Chapter: Stacks & Recursion | BT Level: BT5 | CO: CO2, CO3

Learning Objectives

- Trace PUSH and POP operations step by step
 - Implement the parenthesis matching algorithm using a stack
 - Extend matching to multiple bracket types
 - Apply stack-based validation to real programming scenarios
-

1. Detailed PUSH and POP Operations

1.1 PUSH (Add to Top)

```
Algorithm PUSH(stack, item):  
    if stack.top == capacity - 1:  
        raise Overflow  
    stack.top ← stack.top + 1  
    stack[stack.top] ← item
```

Trace: Push 5, 10, 15 into empty stack (capacity=5):

Operation top Stack State

Initial	-1	[]
push(5)	0	[5]
push(10)	1	[5, 10]
push(15)	2	[5, 10, 15]

1.2 POP (Remove from Top)

```
Algorithm POP(stack):  
    if stack.top == -1:  
        raise Underflow  
    item ← stack[stack.top]  
    stack.top ← stack.top - 1  
    return item
```

Trace continued:

Operation top Stack State Returned

pop()	1	[5, 10]	15
pop()	0	[5]	10

pop()	-1	[]	5
pop()	—	—	Underflow!

2. Parenthesis / Bracket Matching

Problem: Given a string containing brackets `()`, `[]`, `{}`, determine if the brackets are properly matched and nested.

Valid: `()`, `() [] {}`, `{ [ () ] }`, `(( ( )))`

Invalid: `[]`, `( [ ] )`, `{ , ) }`

2.1 Algorithm

```
Algorithm is_balanced(s):
    stack = empty stack
    for each char c in s:
        if c is an opening bracket: push(c)
        elif c is a closing bracket:
            if stack is empty: return False    (no matching opener)
            top = pop()
            if top and c don't match: return False
    return stack is empty    (all openers matched)
```

2.2 Implementation

```
def is_balanced(s):
    stack = []
    matching = {')': '(', ']': '[', '}': '{'}

    for char in s:
        if char in '([{':
            stack.append(char)
        elif char in ')]}':
            if not stack:
                return False    # Nothing to match
            if stack[-1] != matching[char]:
                return False    # Mismatched brackets
            stack.pop()

    return len(stack) == 0    # True if all openers were matched
```

2.3 Detailed Trace — `{ [ ( ) ] }`

Step	Char	Action	Stack
1	{	Push	[{]
2	[	Push	[{, []
3	(	Push	[{, [, (]
4	)	Pop (— matches) ✓	[{, []

```

5    ]    Pop [ — matches ] ✓ [{}]
6    }    Pop { — matches } ✓ []

```

Stack is empty → **Balanced ✓**

2.4 Trace — ([)] (Invalid)

Step	Char	Action	Stack
1	(	Push	[(]
2	[	Push	[(, []
3	)	Top is [, expected (→ mismatch! —	

→ **Not balanced ✗**

3. Extended Applications

3.1 HTML/XML Tag Matching

```

def check_html_tags(html):
    """Check that HTML opening and closing tags are properly nested."""
    import re
    stack = []
    # Find all tags: <div>, </div>, <p>, etc.
    tags = re.findall(r'</?[a-zA-Z]+>', html)

    for tag in tags:
        if not tag.startswith('</'):
            # Opening tag — extract name and push
            tag_name = tag[1:-1]
            stack.append(tag_name)
        else:
            # Closing tag
            tag_name = tag[2:-1]
            if not stack or stack[-1] != tag_name:
                return False
            stack.pop()

    return len(stack) == 0

print(check_html_tags("<div><p></p></div>")) # True
print(check_html_tags("<div><p></div></p>")) # False

```

3.2 Minimum Bracket Additions to Make Valid

```

def min_additions_to_balance(s):
    """
    Returns minimum number of brackets to add/remove to balance s.
    """

```

```

open_count = 0    # Unmatched '('
close_count = 0   # Unmatched ')'

for c in s:
    if c == '(':
        open_count += 1
    elif c == ')':
        if open_count > 0:
            open_count -= 1    # Matched
        else:
            close_count += 1  # Unmatched closing

return open_count + close_count

```

3.3 Score of Parentheses (LeetCode #856)

```

def score_of_parentheses(s):
    """
    () = 1 point, (A) = 2*score(A), AB = score(A) + score(B)
    """
    stack = [0]    # Start with 0 (represents outer scope)
    for c in s:
        if c == '(':
            stack.append(0)
        else:    # c == ')'
            v = stack.pop()
            stack[-1] += max(2 * v, 1)
    return stack[0]

print(score_of_parentheses("()"))    # 1
print(score_of_parentheses("(())")) # 2
print(score_of_parentheses("()()")) # 2
print(score_of_parentheses("((()))")) # 4

```

4. Complexity Analysis

Algorithm	Time	Space
Is Balanced	$O(n)$	$O(n)$ worst case
Min Additions	$O(n)$	$O(1)$
Score of Parentheses	$O(n)$	$O(n)$

Each character is pushed/popped at most once $\rightarrow O(n)$ total operations.

5. Stack Size Analysis

The maximum stack size during parenthesis matching equals the **maximum nesting depth**:

- `((((( ))) ) )` — depth 5 $\rightarrow$ max stack size 5

- `() () () ()` — depth 1 $\rightarrow$ max stack size 1

For a string of length n , worst case stack size is $n/2$ (all opening brackets first) $\rightarrow O(n)$ space.

Summary

- **PUSH:** $O(1)$ — increment top and place element.
 - **POP:** $O(1)$ — retrieve element and decrement top.
 - Parenthesis matching: scan left to right, push openers, pop on closer and verify match.
 - Valid if and only if: every closer matches its opener AND stack is empty at end.
 - Time: $O(n)$, Space: $O(n)$ for the stack.
 - Extends naturally to HTML validation, expression parsing, etc.
-

References

- Cormen et al., *Introduction to Algorithms*, Ch. 10.1 (MIT Press, 2022)
- LeetCode #20 (Valid Parentheses), #856 (Score of Parentheses)